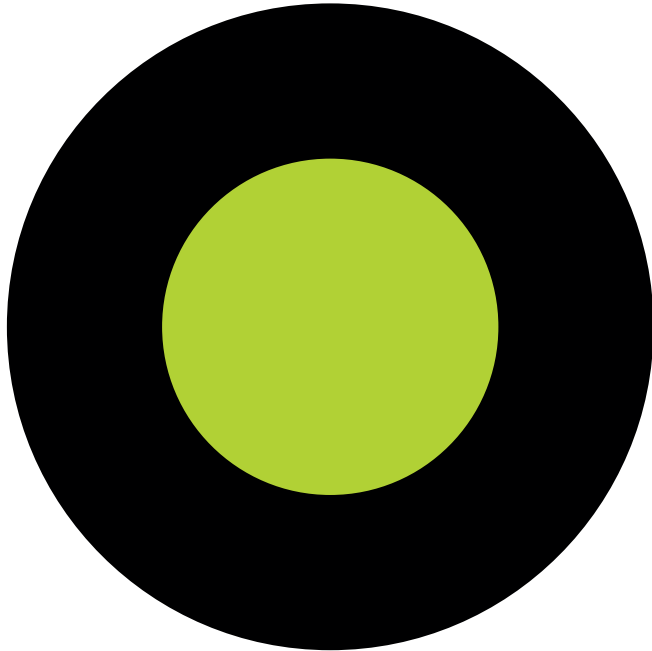




28 |

Ola's 425,000 sq. ft office campus in Bengaluru's Koramangala exemplifies how the company's 36-year-old Founder and CEO Bhavish Aggarwal sees the future of mobility in India.

Just like he consolidated different offices in the city into one campus, he wants to build a similar mobility ecosystem so that his ride hailing, electric vehicle, used cars and other businesses can form a mobility super app of sorts. Impressive? Yes. But like most things in life, it's easier said than done. However, Aggarwal is unperturbed. "Any disruption will have its challenges. Maybe

going forward, we have to become better at anticipating them," he says, in an interaction with *Business Today* for this story.

In February 2021, Aggarwal commenced the ambitious task of building the world's largest two-wheeler factory with 10 million annual capacity spread across 500 acres, 33 per cent of which is fully operational today (the current conventional two-wheeler

market leader, Hero MotoCorp, has an annual capacity of 9 million across eight factories). Ola's factory is expected to be near completion by the end of 2022. Aggarwal's vision of building a mobility ecosystem depends a lot on Ola Electric's success. But that journey has been far from sweet.

After having made bookings in July 2021, customers had to wait till December for the deliveries to begin. Then there were scores of customer complaints on social media platforms, safety concerns kept aggravating, and senior-level exits put a question mark on the company's work culture. Despite the troubles, Ola Electric has taken pole position in the nascent electric two-wheeler space in FY23 (see chart 'The Upstart'). To sustain this growth momentum, though, Aggarwal will need to course correct as he moves to launch an electric car in two years.

TURBULENT START

During its e-scooter launch in August 2021, Ola Electric had promised to deliver the scooter by October. After much delay—made worse by semiconductor shortages and other supply side issues—Ola S1 scooters finally started rolling out of the new Krishnagiri factory in Tamil Nadu in mid-December. At least five former employees told *BT* that concerns around battery overheating were well known from the start, yet there was pressure to meet the December deadline.

Soon after it began delivering door-to-door, one customer complained that the front suspension had broken. In another case, the company made a customer's telemetry data public while defending itself against an